



Learning English with *The Prom* Video

Master vocabulary, idioms, and 90s
American culture through Season 2,
Episode 14 of the world's favorite sitcom.



Intermediate/Advanced

THE ULTIMATE FAN FAVORITE

FAST FACTS

-  **Aired:** February 1, 1996
-  **Director:** James Burrows
-  **Cultural Impact:** Voted the best episode of the series by 1.6 million fans in a 2004 poll; ranked #1 all-time by Gawker.



SYNOPSIS

The friends gather to watch an old home movie from high school. Hidden on the VHS tape is a secret that changes Ross and Rachel's relationship forever.



MUST SEE
MOMENT



GAME
CHANGER





LIGM'S BROCEET

Joey buys Chandler a gaudy gold bracelet to say thank you. Chandler hates it, loses it, and scrambles to replace it.



CHILDHOOD KEEPSAKE.

Monica gets fired, bombs a humiliating restaurant interview, and has to borrow money from her parents.



LIVE LOBSRIUM

Ross begs Rachel for forgiveness. She refuses, until an old VHS tape reveals his hidden romantic gesture.

A hand is reaching out from the left side of the frame towards a gold bracelet that is resting on a brown velvet cushion of a sofa. The background is a warm, out-of-focus interior with a brick wall and a window showing a cityscape at sunset. The entire scene is framed by a decorative border with stars and wavy lines.

Vocabulary: The Unwanted Gift

Gaudy (adj.):

Extremely bright and showy, but tasteless and cheap-looking.
(Context: The gold bracelet Joey buys).

Head shots (n.):

Professional photographs used by actors to get auditions.
(Context: What Chandler paid for to help Joey).

Tacky (adj.):

Showing poor taste or style.

To make amends (v.):

To do something good to show you are sorry for hurting someone.
(Context: Chandler buying a second bracelet).



Vocabulary: Career Setbacks

- **To get fired:** To lose your job because your boss forces you to leave.

Example: Monica tells her parents she got fired from the restaurant.

- **Savings account:** A bank account where you keep money for the future.

Example: Monica's dad tells her to use the 10% of her paycheck she put in her savings.

- **Humiliation:** A strong feeling of embarrassment and loss of pride.

Example: Monica suffers a humiliation conga when her interviewer turns out to have a weird fetish for women making salads.

The Lobster Theory

“It’s a known fact that lobsters fall in love and mate for life. You can actually see old lobster couples walking around their tank, holding claws.” — Phoebe



In English pop culture, “to be someone’s lobster” means to be their soulmate—the person they are destined to be with forever, no matter what happens.



Grammar in Context: 'Used To'

We use used to + base verb to describe past habits or states that are no longer true.

- Monica used to be heavier. (The audience meets “Fat Monica” for the first time).
- Rachel used to have a much larger nose.
- Ross used to have an afro and a moustache (looking like Gabe Kaplan).



Phrasal Verb: To Stand (Someone) Up

Definition: To fail to meet someone for a planned romantic date without telling them.

Context: In the video, Rachel is waiting for her date, Chip Matthews. When he is late, the friends worry that Chip has stood her up.

Grammar Note: This verb is separable. (e.g., 'Chip stood Rachel up' or 'Chip stood up Rachel').



Idiom Spotlight: 'Clobbered'

"I fall for you and I get clobbered, you then fall for me and I again, somehow, get clobbered." — Rachel

Literal Meaning: To be hit very hard physically.

Sitcom Meaning: To be emotionally defeated, rejected, or badly hurt in a relationship. Rachel is tired of being emotionally hurt by Ross.

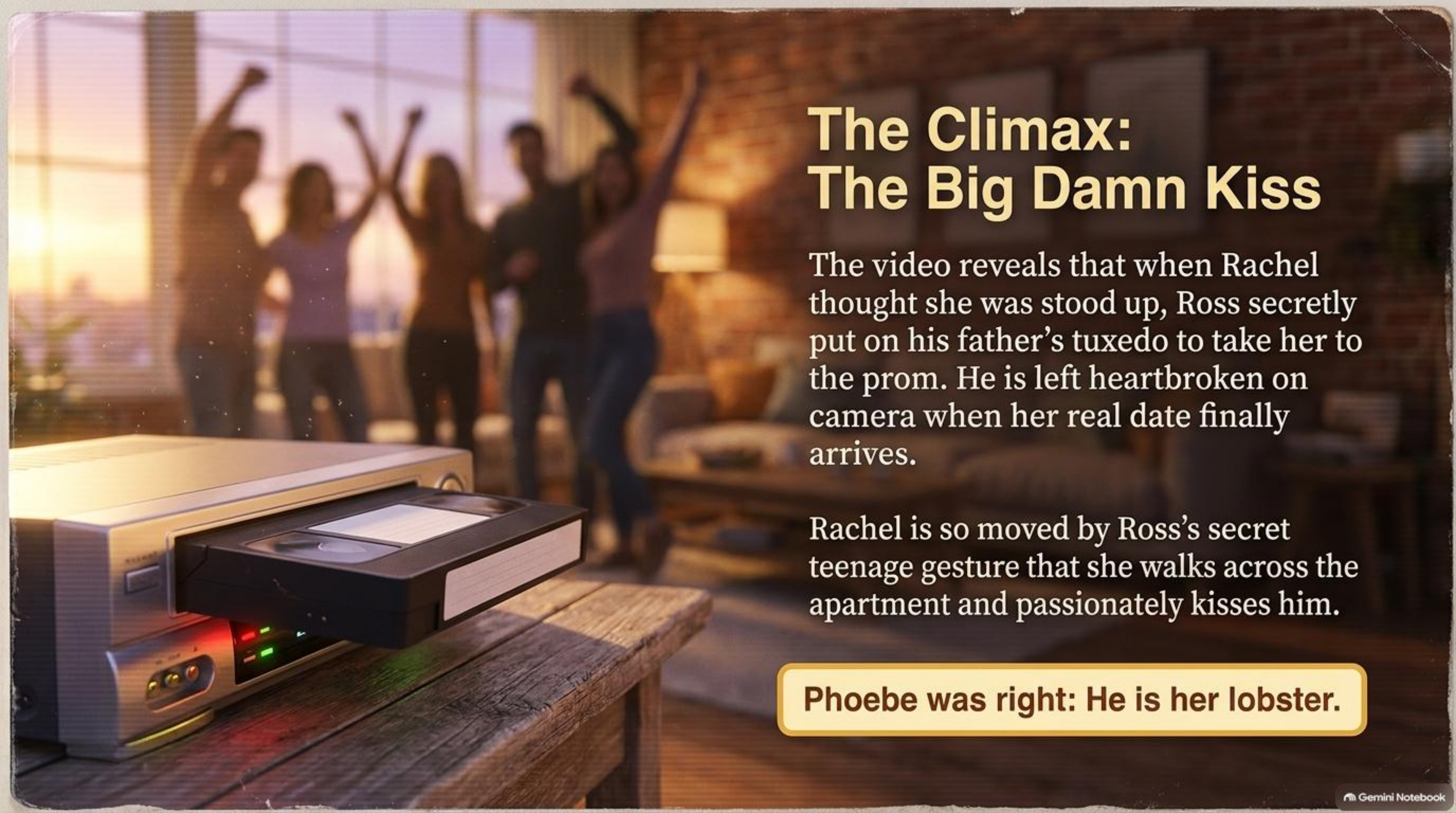
90s Cultural Context

① **Technologically Blind Elders:** A common 90s sitcom joke where older parents struggle to use technology, leaving the camera recording when they think it is off.

② **Saw Star Wars 27 Times:** Monica's date watched Star Wars hundreds of times. In 1988, this required owning an expensive, giant "laserdisc" player!

③ **The Home Movie:** Before smartphones, families recorded events on physical tapes. Jack and Judy accidentally recorded over the end of the prom video with their own private tape.



A VHS tape is shown in a VCR, which is placed on a wooden surface. In the background, a group of people are dancing and celebrating in a room with large windows, suggesting a party or prom scene. The overall atmosphere is warm and nostalgic.

The Climax: The Big Damn Kiss

The video reveals that when Rachel thought she was stood up, Ross secretly put on his father's tuxedo to take her to the prom. He is left heartbroken on camera when her real date finally arrives.

Rachel is so moved by Ross's secret teenage gesture that she walks across the apartment and passionately kisses him.

Phoebe was right: He is her lobster.

Comprehension Check: True or False?

1. Joey gives Chandler a gold bracelet because Chandler helped pay for his acting head shots. (T/F)
2. Monica's parents refuse to lend her any money after she gets fired. (T/F)
3. The phrase "to be someone's lobster" means you are enemies for life. (T/F)
4. In the video, Ross successfully takes Rachel to the high school prom. (T/F)

Answers at the end of the deck!

Comprehension Check: Short Answer

1. Why does Chandler buy a second gold bracelet?

2. What does Monica's interviewer have a strange fetish for?

3. What embarrassing secret do Monica and the group discover at the very end of the VHS tape?



Coffee Shop Chat: Discussion Prompts

Have you ever received a “gaudy” or unwanted gift from a friend? How did you react? Did you hide your true feelings?

Do you believe in Phoebe’s “lobster” theory? Do people have one soulmate they are meant to be with for life?

Think about your own past habits. Using the grammar structure from today, write three sentences about what you “used to” do when you were a teenager.



Answer Key

True/False:

1. True
2. False (They offer her savings, but Ross writes a check)
3. False (It means soulmates)
4. False (Chip arrives before Ross can ask her)

Short Answer:

1. He loses the first one and wants to make amends.
2. Women making salads.
3. A video of Monica's parents having sex.

Great job! Keep watching, keep practicing, and see you next episode.